



New GPS data for boat Nolan Wells was on before disappearance
(01:38)

FIRST ON CBS [U.S.](#)

GPS data tracks boat Mississippi teen Nolan Wells was on before he went missing

By Jared Eggleston, [Skyler Henry](#), [Anna Schechter](#)

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GPS data from the Mississippi Department of Marine Resources, obtained by CBS News, tracks the movements of the boat that carried [Nolan Wells](#) to Horn Island on July 4. [Wells was found dead](#) after going missing following an outing on the island.

The vessel left a dock at approximately 9:56 a.m. that morning and arrived at Horn Island at 11:14 a.m. CBS News has previously reported that Wells was not on the boat when it departed the island.

According to the GPS data, the boat left Horn Island at 4:31 p.m. and returned to its original departure dock. It then traveled into Fort Bayou around 5:52 p.m. before returning to the dock at 6:06 p.m.

Later that evening, the boat went to the Fort Bayou boat launch at 7:19 p.m., according to the MSDMR report. From there, it traveled over land — presumably towed by a vehicle — to the Biloxi, Mississippi, residence of the boat's owners.

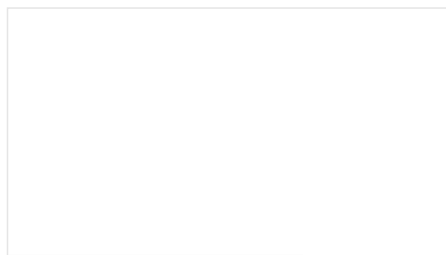
The MSDMR report indicates that the boat's owner, his mother and one other individual who was reportedly with Wells on the day of the incident have cooperated with the investigation.

The department's report ends on July 5, following notification that the Jackson County Sheriff's Office would take over as the lead investigative agency.



This undated photo provided by the family in July 2026 shows Nolan Xavier Wells with his mother, Christine Wonsley. Family photo via AP

Wells, 18, was last seen on July 4 on Horn Island, where he had taken a boat trip with friends to celebrate the holiday, officials said. Wells traveled to the island with his friends but did not return to the mainland with them that afternoon, Jackson County Sheriff John Ledbetter has said.



He was last seen on the island at 3 p.m., according to attorney Ben Crump's office. His mother reported him missing later that night and a search began.

His body was discovered July 6 off the coast of the island, which is about 10 miles south of the Mississippi mainland, following a search that involved the U.S. Coast Guard, the Mississippi Department of Marine Resources and the National Park Service.

Dental records confirmed the body was Wells, Jackson County coroner Bruce Lynd told CBS News. An autopsy took place on July 7, Lynd said, but the results were not immediately made public. Wells' body was flown to Washington, D.C., for an independent autopsy, according to Crump.

Wells' parents have said they don't believe their son would've stayed behind on the island by choice when his friends left by boat.



Christine and Elmore Wonsley, the parents of Nolan Wells, spoke to "CBS Mornings" on Friday, July 10, 2026.

CBS News

"No, he wouldn't. Nolan always stays with the group," Elmore Wonsley, Nolan's father, told "CBS Mornings" last week. "If you be with me, you come back with me. So that I don't understand, and with me being a parent, if I was in that situation, I would have told them, 'You're going to get back on this boat with me because I don't want to answer to your parents if something happens to you.'"

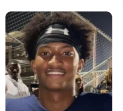
When directly asked if he believed Nolan was left behind on the island, his father responded, "Yes. I don't believe he decided to stay on the island by himself. It just doesn't — that's not his character."

Wells went to Ocean Springs High School and was a rising sophomore on Southwest Mississippi Community College's football team. Crump said Wells was a good swimmer.

Mark Osborne contributed to this report.

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